



SOLDIERS stand outside a massive tent city erected at the Joint Forces Training Base in Los Alamitos.

CASE OF EL CHAPO SCION IS ROILING MEXICO

Ovidio Guzmán López’s deal with U.S. raises speculation he might expose officials.

By Patrick J. McDonnell

MEXICO CITY — A bitter public dispute between Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum and the New York lawyer representing a son of drug kingpin Joaquín “El Chapo” Guzmán has raised speculation here that the deal-seeking scion of the onetime Sinaloa cartel leader may expose corrupt Mexican officials.

On Tuesday, Sheinbaum said she had filed a defamation complaint in Mexico against Jeffrey Lichtman, the high-profile attorney representing Ovidio Guzmán López, who last week pleaded guilty in federal court in Chicago to fentanyl trafficking and other crimes. He has agreed to cooperate with U.S. prosecutors in a bid to reduce a potential life sentence.

In comments after the court hearing, Lichtman labeled as “absurd” Sheinbaum’s repeated contentions that Washington should coordinate with Mexico on the case — especially if, as is widely expected, Guzmán López spills the beans on alleged ties between Mexican offi-

[See Mexico, A4]

Troops face boredom, not unrest, in L.A.

More than a month after Trump mobilized military, ‘there’s not much to do,’ a source says

By Jenny Jarvie, Grace Toohey and Christopher Buchanan

They were deployed by the Trump administration to combat “violent, insurrectionist mobs” in and around Los Angeles, but in recent days the only thing many U.S. Marines and California National Guard troops seemed to be fighting was tedium.

“There’s not much to do,” one Marine said as he stood guard outside the towering Wilshire Federal Building in Westwood this week.

The blazing protests that first met federal immigration raids in downtown Los Angeles were nowhere to be seen along Wilshire Boulevard or Veteran Avenue, so many troops passed the time chatting and joking over energy drinks.

The Marine, who declined to give his name because he was not authorized to speak to reporters, said his duties consisted mostly of approving access for federal workers and visitors to the Veterans Affairs office.

More than five weeks after Trump mobilized an extraordinary show of military force against the will of California Gov. Gavin Newsom and L.A. Mayor Karen Bass, few National Guard troops and Marines have remained in public view, most retreating to local military bases in Orange County.

As an indication of the military’s dwindling role in immigration enforcement operations, U.S.

[See Troops, A6]

Palisades locals say Bass is falling short since fire

Despite some success, L.A. mayor has faced criticism over ability to expedite recovery.

By Julia Wick and Matt Hamilton

Six months to the day that flames ravaged Altadena and Pacific Palisades, Mayor Karen Bass was preparing to mark the occasion alongside Gov. Gavin Newsom and other leaders.

But instead of heading north to the Pasadena news conference last week, the mayor’s black SUV made a detour to MacArthur Park, where a cavalcade of federal agents in tactical gear had descended on the heart of immigrant Los Angeles.

In a seafoam blue suit, Bass muscled her way through the crowds and could be heard on a live news feed pushing the agents to leave.

Ultimately, she sent an underling to join Newsom and U.S. Sen. Alex Padilla to discuss fire rebuilding and recovery, as she held an impromptu City Hall news con-

ference decrying the immigration raid.

This is the delicate dance Bass has found herself doing in recent weeks. Recovering from one of the costliest natural disasters in American history remains a daily slog, even as a new and urgent crisis demands her attention.

The federal immigration assault on Los Angeles has granted Bass a second chance at leading her city through civic catastrophe. Her political image was badly bruised in the wake of the fires, but she has compensated amid a string of historically good headlines.

Killings have plummeted, with Los Angeles on pace for the lowest homicide total in nearly 60 years. Bass has also made progress on the seemingly intractable homelessness crisis for the second consecutive year, with a nearly 8% decrease in the number of people sleeping on city streets in 2024.

But there is a widening gulf between Pacific Palisades, where the annihilation remains palpable as far as the eye can see, and the rest of the city, where attention has largely flickered to

[See Palisades, A14]



MAYOR Karen Bass is trying to balance multiple crises confronting Los Angeles after January’s fires.

Israel bombs Syria amid sectarian violence



SMOKE rises over Damascus after Israel struck Syria’s military headquarters.

Jets pound Damascus as part of tough policy toward Islamist-led new government.

By Nabih Bulos

BEIRUT — Israeli warplanes pounded the Syrian capital of Damascus on Wednesday, escalating a months-long campaign against that government — whose forces are engaged in heavy clashes with the country’s Druze minority.

The roar of jet engines reverberated around Damascus’ downtown districts as Israeli drones and warplanes peppered the Syrian military’s General Staff headquarters with missiles, engulfing sections of the compound in fireballs.

Bombs also were dropped near the presidential palace.

The bombing of Damascus comes as Israel continues to wage a multifront war against most of its neighbors, just weeks after it launched a campaign against Iran in hopes of destroying its nuclear capabilities. On Wednesday, even as it continued fighting in Syria, it launched attacks in Lebanon on what it said were assets for the Iran-backed Lebanese militant group Hezbollah, even while pressing its campaign against Hamas militants in the Gaza Strip.

Israel has hewed to a zero-threat-tolerance policy toward the government of Syria’s interim President Ahmad al-Sharaa, a former Al Qaeda-affiliated rebel leader — he split from the

[See Syria, A4]

Plucky team behind Dave’s Hot Chicken

Three friends started selling spicy tenders in a parking lot. Now it’s a \$1-billion chain.

By Stephanie Breijo

It started in an East Hollywood parking lot: one small fryer, no permits, a few heat lamps and a tent constantly battered by wind.

A trio of friends — all from L.A.’s Armenian community and all high school dropouts — scraped together \$900 in 2017 because they believed that their Nashville-style fried chicken stand was the future.

Now Dave’s Hot Chicken is worth \$1 billion.

This year, the modern specialist in the decades-old spicy fried chicken style that

originated in Nashville became one of L.A.’s most astounding small-business success stories. The chain currently operates about 320 storefronts, with 800 more planned. Dave’s Hot Chicken has opened as many as five new locations in a day. (“Oh, we’ve done that multiple times,” co-founder Arman Oganessian said casually.)

The spiced, craggy, neon-red chicken tenders and sandwiches can now be found in London and Dubai just as easily as in Hollywood and Ladera Heights.

And those are now valuable globe-trotting chicken tenders. In June, private equity firm Roark Capital acquired the homespun chain, which began with a five-month renegade stint, valuing Dave’s at \$1 billion.

[See Dave’s, A11]

Trump slams own supporters

President lashes out over what he now calls the Jeffrey Epstein “hoax.” NATION, A5

Girardi to begin prison sentence

Officials will consider ex-lawyer’s dementia to find right place for him. CALIFORNIA, B1

The best era of Disneyland?

A ride through the park’s ups and downs from 1955 to 2025. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 81/62. B6

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California regions are poised for success in AI, study says

By Queenie Wong

Despite suggestions it has been losing its edge, California is way ahead of others when it comes to the hottest technology right now: artificial intelligence.

The regions around San Francisco, San Jose and Los Angeles are among the top ranked in the country for AI, according to a report released Wednesday by the Brookings Institution.

The Washington think tank dubbed the San Francisco and San Jose metropolitan areas “superstars” when it comes to having everything in place to launch big AI businesses. Three of the top 10 city regions most ready for AI are in California, according to the report. No other state has more than one region in the top 10.

Texas had none in Brookings’ top 10. Austin was ranked 11th.

With tech giants such as Google, Meta and Nvidia headquartered in Northern California and OpenAI securing a record-breaking \$40 billion in funding and teaming up with California universities to bring its AI chatbot ChatGPT to campuses this year, it’s no surprise that the Bay Area cities dominate.

“They really are in a class of their own, given the sheer scale, dominant big tech headquarters, massive research labs and venture capital,” said Mark Muro, a senior fellow at the metropolitan policy program at Brookings who co-wrote the study.

Los Angeles, home to top-tier universities, film studios, defense tech start-

ups, social networks and dating apps, is also a big AI contender. The Los Angeles metro area, which includes Long Beach and Anaheim, is part of the second-highest cluster of AI-ready regions. Brookings calls “star hubs,” the report said.

The analysis shows how California metropolitan areas are among the most prepared for AI, technology with the potential to reshape industries as diverse as healthcare and entertainment. The San Diego metro

[See Hubs, A10]

3 things about \$4-trillion firm

Nvidia is the most valuable company in the world. How did it get there? BUSINESS, A9